WHAT'S CHANGING IN SKIN TREATMENT

Moving beyond antihistamines, new therapies target specific nerve pathways and immune signals that drive itching

ECZEMA

What it is

- Red, dry, scaly patches that itch intensely
- A weakened skin barrier, overactive immunity and imbalanced skin bacteria sustain inflammation
- Steroid creams are a standard treatment for flare-ups

New treatments

- Newer options include biologics such as dupilumab, which block specific immune signals, and Janus kinase (JAK) inhibitors, which block proteins that relay these signals inside cells
- Non-steroid creams, such as tacrolimus and pimecrolimus, can control inflammation without the skin-thinning risks associated with prolonged steroid use

PRURIGO NODULARIS

What it is

- Hard, intensely itchy bumps, often on the arms, legs and torso
- Over-sensitive nerves and inflammation fuel the itch-scratch cycle
- Standard treatments include steroid creams to reduce inflammation

New treatments

- Newer drugs such as nemolizumab block IL-31, an immune signal closely involved in carrying itch messages between the immune system and nerves, helping reduce severe itching and break the itch-scratch cycle

FUNGAL DISEASE

What it is

- Itchy, scaly, sometimes ring-shaped patches on the skin
- Some fungal strains resist standard antifungal medicines, making infections harder to clear

New treatments

- Laboratory tests, including fungal culture and antifungal susceptibility testing, can identify the fungus and determine which drugs it remains sensitive to, helping doctors choose alternatives when standard treatment fails

CONTACT DERMATITIS

What it is

- Red, itchy, irritated or blistered skin
- Develops where skin contacts triggers such as cosmetics, perfume, jewellery, fabrics etc.
- Traditionally treated by moisturising the skin and using short courses of topical steroid creams when needed

New treatments

- Patch and photopatch testing can pinpoint allergens in cosmetics, fragrances and hair products, helping identify and avoid triggers
- JAK inhibitors, which target inflammatory pathways, are being studied for skin diseases but are not standard treatment for ordinary dermatitis



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